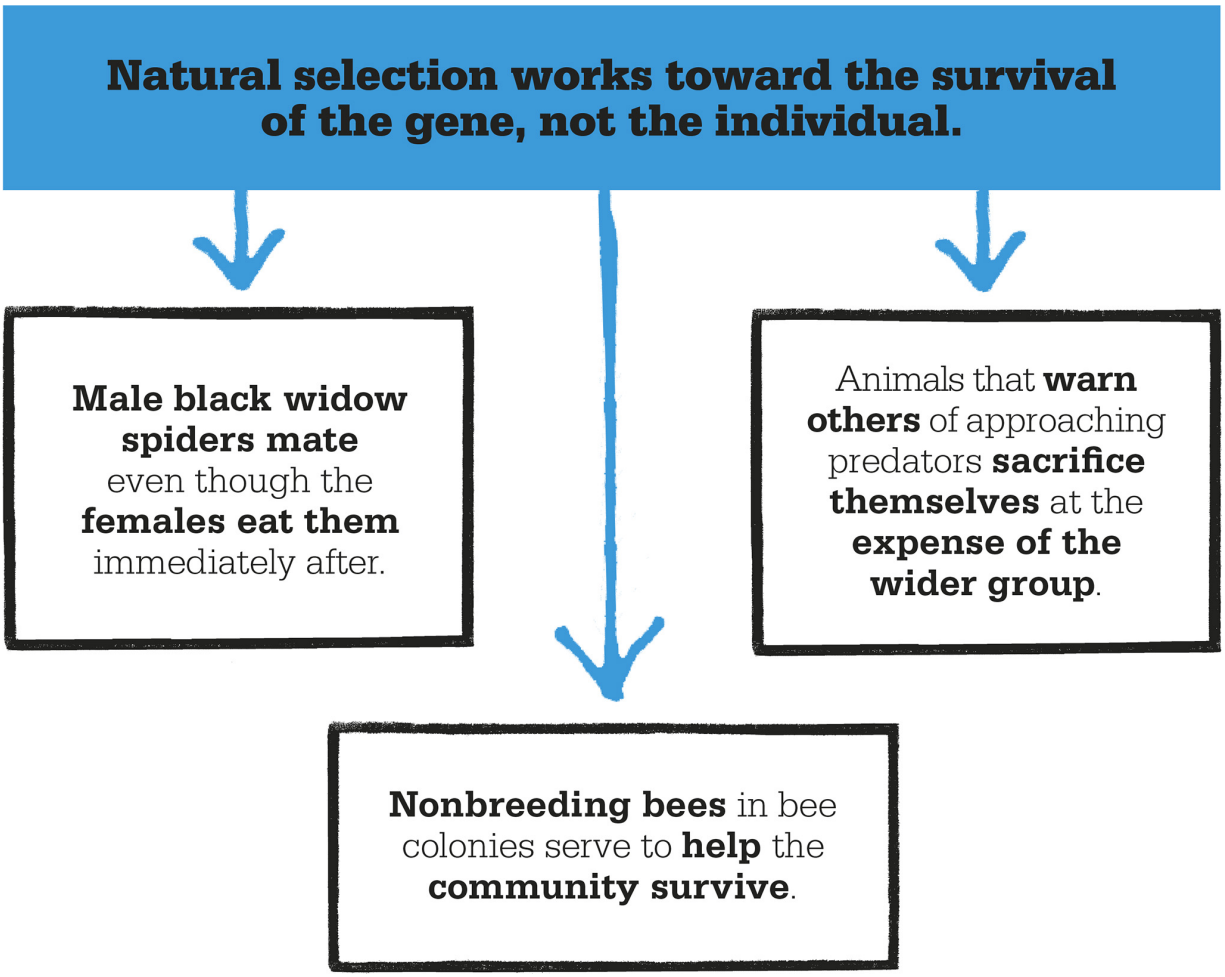


Read accessible description

Selfishness and altruism

Gene selfishness usually gives rise to selfishness in the behavior of an individual organism, but there are circumstances in which the gene can achieve its own selfish goals by fostering apparent altruism in the organism. One example is kin selection, the evolutionary strategy that favours the reproductive success of an individual organism's relatives, even at the cost of the individual's own reproduction or survival.

An extreme example of genetically based altruism is eusociality. Honey bees are a eusocial species. They live in colonies which include breeding and nonbreeding individuals. By helping the colony survive, the many